

Puccini created the three works that define his place in operatic history: *La Bohème*, *Tosca*, and *Madama Butterfly*. Of these, *La Bohème* was the most rapid popular success. *Tosca*, first performed in Rome in 1900 before an upper-class audience unnerved by a threat of anarchist bombing, was criticized for its violent scenes of torture and murder, but also soon achieved international popularity. However, Puccini's Japan-set opera *Madama Butterfly* met with a hostile reception at its premiere in 1904: some critics said it was a "fiasco," others that there had been insufficient rehearsal time; Puccini himself was adamant that its poor reception was engineered by his rivals. But following substantial revisions, the emotional warmth and dramatic intensity of Puccini's score combined with the heartbreaking story—of a teenage Japanese bride who is abandoned by her US soldier husband and kills herself—finally met with acclaim.

Crisis and tragedy

Success brought Puccini wealth and fame. He could indulge his taste for fast cars—then a rich man's novelty—and attractive mistresses. Often left alone at Torre del Lago, Elvira raged at Puccini's infidelities, especially his passionate affair with a young woman in Turin, who is known to history only as "Corinna."

In 1903, while he was still working on *Madama Butterfly*, Puccini was seriously injured in a car accident. Around the same time, Elvira's husband died. His demise obliged Puccini to legitimize the relationship, although by that time he would probably have preferred a separation.